State Education Policy (SEP) for Tamil Nadu, 'keeping in mind the interests of the education/future of the youth of the state'.

Besides the NEP, the DMK is also opposed to the centralised National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) for admissions to medical colleges. "We are not opposing them (NEP and NEET) out of fear. Our position is that education must decide one's status and not vice versa. It is a huge injustice to claim one can study (medicine) only if he or she qualifies (an exam)," Stalin reasoned at the conference.

The sequence of events clearly suggests that this fight for getting a say in the appointment of V-Cs at its core conceals the DMK government's desire to shape the state's higher education policies, which it wants rooted in 'social justice, federalism, pluralism and equality'. In fact, 'autonomy to the state, federalism at the Centre' has been a decades-old slogan of the DMK, and the party has also been demanding that education be brought back from the Concurrent List to the State List.

However, this government-governor tussle has the V-Cs in a fix, as they can't simply ignore the state's top executive, who as the chancellor, derives his powers from the university statutes. Any friction will clearly hamper their functioning, with university syndicates—which also have the governor's nominees—likely to turn into battlegrounds. "The logical way to resolve this issue is to respect the federal rights and let the elected government make decisions best suited to the state," says Aazhi Senthilnathan, a Chennai-based federal and language rights activist. Governor Ravi is unlikely to give in to such a demand. ■

FROM RUSSIA WITH LOVE

$9.87 bn (Rs 78,960 cr.) India's imports from Russia in 2021-22

$3.25 bn (Rs 26,000 cr.) India's exports to Russia in 2021-22

$6.62 bn (Rs 52,960 cr.) Trade deficit with Russia in 2021-22

$3.2 bn (Rs 25,600 cr.) India's crude oil imports from Russia in April-May 2022, compared to just **$210 mn** in March

KEY IMPORTS
Crude oil, defence equipment, mineral oils, agriculture products, coal, pearls, fertilisers and nuclear reactors

KEY EXPORTS
Electrical machinery and equipment, pharmaceutical products, nuclear reactor parts and organic chemicals

INDIA VACILLATED ON AN EXCHANGE RATE FOR THE ROUBLE-RUPEE TRADE. WITH THE ROUBLE FIRMING UP, A DEAL WILL NOT BE EASY NOW

has already delayed fixing an exchange rate for the rouble-rupee trade, which could diminish its negotiating prospects with Russia. "When the idea of a rupee-rouble trade was mooted, the rouble was crashing for a couple of months. At that point, it could have been easier for India to fix the exchange rate, for we would have been negotiating with a partner with a collapsing currency," says Biswajit Dhar, professor at the Centre for Economic Studies and Planning, Jawaharlal Nehru University. "The Indian government had the political will to do business with Russia from day one. So, maybe we should have sealed the deal quickly. But we dilly-dallied, and now there's a problem."

Indeed, despite the sanctions, Russia has not only found new partners, it is motoring on quite well. Not only has the rouble stabilised, it has also strengthened quite a bit. The currency, which had weakened to 138.7 to a dollar on March 9, days after Russia's Ukraine invasion, has since strengthened to 61.5 to a dollar by September 11. This is not surprising, since exports from Russia are rising. "In April-June last year, Russia was the 19th largest import destination for India. In the corresponding period this year, it is the sixth largest," Dhar adds. Apart from crude oil, Russia's exports to India include defence equipment, mineral oils, agri products, coal, pearls, fertilisers and nuclear reactors.

In 2012, India had designated Kolkata-based UCO Bank as the payment bank for Iranian oil after that country was hit by sanctions. This time too, the choice could be UCO Bank, since it does not have too much forex exposure, says Dhar. Experts say that with the rupees that Russian firms get, they can import goods from India or invest in Indian government securities. "The rupees given cannot be converted into rouble since no exchange rate has been fixed between the two countries," says Madan Sabnavis, chief economist of the Bank of Baroda. "Once you fix the exchange rate, the money goes into the government's coffers and the government can give rupees to those people who want to buy goods from India." As for repercussions from the US, "the government and the RBI have been trying to give assurances that nothing will happen", he adds. Creating a robust financial mechanism for the rupee-rouble trade is of utmost importance in furthering India's trade interests with Russia. But it may not be so easy. Indian banks will need a lot of guidance from the RBI and the Centre in this regard. ■